Beyond clausal ellipsis: a relational approach to exceptive constructions

Abstract
This paper argues against clausal-ellipsis analyses of exceptive constructions and develops a phrasal alternative grounded in the internal syntax of relational/adpositional structures. Focusing on Italian tranne, eccetto, and related markers, we show that (i) inclusion effects and (ii) the distribution of PP and CP complements pose non-trivial challenges for derivations that require clausal source structures plus TP-deletion. We propose that subtractive exceptive markers instantiate an Axial Part/Relational Noun within a double-relator configuration. On this view, DP complements are licensed by an ordinary lower relator, while PP/CP complements are mediated by a linker (*che*) that satisfies categorial selection. We further argue that apparent "multiple remnants" are compatible with a phrasal syntax when the exception targets a polyadic quantificational domain. The resulting analysis reduces reliance on silent clausal structure and yields new predictions about complement type, linker realization, and cross-linguistic variation in exceptive marking.
Keywords: exceptive constructions, clausal ellipsis, Axial Parts, adpositions, Italian.

1. Introduction: Theoretical background on Exceptive Phrases

Exceptive constructions have long posed a challenge for theories of the syntax–semantics interface. Expressions such as English *except* and *but*, Spanish *excepto*, and Italian *tranne*, *eccetto*, *salvo* operate on quantified expressions to subtract a specified entity or set of entities from the domain of quantification.

Formal semantic treatments of exceptives emerged in the 1990s. Von Fintel (1993) proposes that exceptives like English *but* encode domain subtraction coupled with a *Uniqueness/Leastness* condition. This condition ensures that the exception set is the unique, minimal set whose subtraction from the quantifier's domain makes the quantificational statement true, thus capturing why exceptives are highly restricted to combining with universal or negative universal quantifiers (the Quantifier Constraint), as illustrated in (1).

(1) a. Every student but John attended the meeting.
b. No student but John attended the meeting.
c. *Some student but John attended the meeting.

Moltmann (1995) further broadened the empirical discussion by examining the Homogeneity Condition and highlighting the problem of multiple remnants, as illustrated in (2). She argues that such constructions involve polyadic quantification, in which the exception corresponds to an n-tuple that is subtracted from a complex polyadic domain.

(2) Every boy danced with every girl except John with Mary.

A major descriptive and theoretical contribution is due to Hoeksema (1995), who introduced the widely adopted distinction between *Connected Exceptives* (CEs) and *Free Exceptives* (FEs). Connected Exceptives modify a nominal host and must occur adjacent to the quantified noun phrase, whereas Free Exceptives display greater distributional flexibility, functioning as modifiers that can appear in detached or fronted positions. This typological contrast is clearly observable across Romance languages, such as Spanish, as illustrated in (3).

(3) Spanish

a. El proyecto recibió el apoyo de todas las
the project receive.PST.3SG the support of all the
comunidades, excepto el País Vasco. (CE)
autonomous.regions except the Basque Country
'The project received the support of all the autonomous regions except the Basque Country.'

b. Había charlado con todos, salvo con los muchachos
have.PST.3SG talked with all except with the fellows
del Simca. (FE)
of.the Simca
'He had talked to everybody, except to the Simca fellows.'

This distinction has given rise to an extended debate concerning the mapping between the syntactic structure and the semantic interpretation of exceptive constructions. From a semantic perspective, scholars have investigated whether exceptive phrases (EPs) uniformly operate on quantifiers (Moltmann 1995; Reinhart 1991), or whether a non-uniform analysis is required, according to which Connected Exceptives denote sets subtracted from nominal domains, while Free Exceptives denote propositions (Hoeksema 1995). More recently, work in formal semantics has explored *distributed* or exhaustification-based approaches (Gajewski 2008, 2013; Hirsch 2016; Crnič 2018), which aim to derive the characteristic subtractive and exhaustive inferences of exceptive constructions without positing complex primitive operators.

From a morphosyntactic perspective, the status of the exceptive marker remains a matter of debate. Moltmann (1995) analyzes exceptives as prepositions projecting a PP, whereas more recent work has favored coordination-based and ellipsis-based analyses. In a detailed study of the Spanish markers *excepto*, *salvo*, and *menos*, Pérez-Jiménez and Moreno-Quibén (2012) argue that exceptive markers function as coordinating conjunctions heading a Boolean Phrase. On their account, the distinction between Connected and Free Exceptives reflects the level of coordination: Connected Exceptives involve DP-level coordination, whereas Free Exceptives involve full CP-level coordination. In the latter case, they propose that an empty C head licenses TP-deletion (ellipsis), leaving the constituent following the exceptive marker as the sole overt remnant.

Building on early insights by Harris (1982), Vostrikova (2019, 2021) has extensively expanded this clausal ellipsis hypothesis for English *except*, arguing that the marker introduces a fully-fledged clausal structure that is subsequently reduced by *stripping*. Under this clausal ellipsis approach, a sentence such as *Every girl came except Eva* is derived from a bi-clausal underlying source: *Every girl came, except Eva did not come*, where the polarity mismatch is resolved through a highly specialized deletion operation licensed by "Conditional Leastness". Vostrikova (2021) draws on evidence from prepositional remnants and multiple remnants to argue for an underlying clausal structure, as illustrated in (4).

(4) a. I got no presents except from my mom.

b. (Underlying structure) ... except I got presents from my mom.

In a similar vein, Potsdam and Polinsky (2019) have proposed a typological split: while some languages like English utilize a clausal ellipsis derivation, others genuinely employ phrasal exceptives (e.g., Russian *krome*, which crucially assigns genitive case and prohibits clausal remnants or multiple exceptions), as in (5).

(5) Russian

Vse	deti	za-plaka-l-i,	krome	Maš-i.
All	children	INCH-cry-PST-PL	except	Masha-GEN

'All the children started crying, except Masha.'

The present analysis departs from clausal ellipsis accounts and adopts a strictly phrasal perspective on exceptive constructions. We argue that exceptive phrases (EPs) do not involve unpronounced clausal structure, but are instead fundamentally relational in nature. Building on the *Double-Relator Model* (DRM) developed for spatial (and abstract) adpositions (Franco 2024; Franco & Schirato 2026), we propose that exceptive markers are best analyzed as *Axial Parts* (AxPs) or *Relational Nouns* (RelNs). On this view, exceptive constructions are embedded within a syntactic configuration that parallels the structure of complex spatial adpositions. The semantics of exceptives is grounded in a *mereological* perspective. Rather than treating exception as the simple mirror image of partitivity, we argue that exceptive constructions involve a relation of *zonal exclusion*, which can be understood as the inverse counterpart of *zonal inclusion* in the sense of Belvin and den Dikken (1997). As will be shown through a structural parallel with abessive constructions (expressing absence), operations of zonal exclusion require a more articulated syntactic configuration—namely the projection of an Axial Part — than relations of partitive (or comitative/instrumental) inclusion. Within a minimalist framework (Chomsky 1995), which favors the minimal syntactic structure necessary to interface with phonological and semantic interpretation, the DRM provides a principled account of the distribution of exceptive phrases without positing silent clausal structure, special ellipsis-licensing mechanisms, or clausal coordination.

2. The Clausal Ellipsis Hypothesis: Empirical and Theoretical Shortcomings

Recent work has increasingly explored *clausal analyses* of exceptive constructions**,** including Pérez-Jiménez and Moreno-Quibén (2012) for Spanish, Vostrikova (2021) for English, and Potsdam and Polinsky (2019) in a broader crosslinguistic perspective. These approaches share the assumption that exceptive markers introduce a clausal coordination structure, and that the elements following the marker correspond to remnants of an elided clause, typically derived through TP-ellipsis or stripping. Under this view, the apparent presence of non-DP remnants receives a straightforward explanation: if an exceptive phrase can host a prepositional phrase or multiple constituents, these elements are analyzed as remnants of a larger clausal structure. Since prepositional phrases or *n*-tuples cannot directly restrict a nominal domain, they are taken to reflect an underlying reduced clause. Consider the analysis proposed for Spanish by Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén (2012: 591) in (6b) for (6a). In their proposal, the exceptive marker heads a Boolean Phrase (BP) that coordinates two clausal structures. The first conjunct corresponds to the overt clause (*Hicimos mil cosas* ‘we did a thousand things'), while the second conjunct contains a full clausal structure whose TP is deleted.[1]

(6) Spanish

a. Hicimos mil cosas, excepto ir a la playa.
do.PST.1PL thousand things except go.INF to the beach
'We did everything but go to the beach.'

b. [$_{CP1}$ [$_{CP1}$ Hicimos mil cosas] [$_{BP}$ excepto [$_{CP2}$ [$_{VPi}$ ir a la playa] [$_{CP2}$ C[E] <[$_{TP}$ T [t_i]]>]]]]

However, when this hypothesis is examined more closely — particularly in light of Italian morphosyntax — it encounters several empirical and theoretical difficulties. Analyses that posit silent clausal structure and additional functional material to account for the surface distribution of exceptive phrases risk obscuring the relational properties that characterize these constructions.

2.1 A Semantic Mismatch: Coordination vs. Domain Subtraction

As discussed above, Pérez-Jiménez and Moreno-Quibén (2012) analyze exceptive markers as Boolean coordinators. If exceptive markers were simply coordinating conjunctions introducing an elliptical clause, we would expect their semantic behavior to parallel that of genuine adversative coordinators, such as Italian *ma non* ('but not'). However, the empirical evidence suggests otherwise: exceptive constructions are subject to a well-known semantic constraint, commonly referred to as the *Condition of Inclusion* (or *Homogeneity Condition*, see Moltmann 1995). This constraint requires that the entities identified as exceptions be mereologically included within the restriction of the associated quantifier. The contrast becomes particularly clear in the "penguin test" illustrated in (7) for Italian.

(7) Italian

a. Ho visto tutti i mammiferi allo zoo, ma non

[1] The representation in (6b) reflects this derivation. The outer CP coordinates two clauses. The first CP hosts the overt clause *Hicimos mil cosas*. The second conjunct is introduced by the Boolean head *excepto*, which selects a CP complement. Inside this CP, the infinitival phrase *ir a la playa* 'to go to the beach' originates as the complement of the verb phrase in the lower clause. Prior to ellipsis, this constituent undergoes movement to the left periphery of the exceptive clause, leaving a trace inside TP. The TP containing the trace is subsequently deleted under ellipsis, licensed by an empty C head. As a result, the moved constituent survives as the *remnant* of the ellipsis site. In sum, the structure corresponds to an underlying biclausal representation roughly paraphrasable as *Hicimos mil cosas, excepto que no hicimos ir a la playa*, where the TP of the second clause is deleted, leaving only the remnant *ir a la playa*.

have.1SG	seen	all	the	mammals	at.the zoo		but	not
(ho	visto)	i	pinguini.					
have.1SG	seen	the	penguins					

'I saw all the mammals at the zoo, but I didn't see the penguins.'

b.

# Ho	visto	tutti	i	mammiferi	allo	zoo	tranne	i
have.1SG	seen	all	the	mammals	at.the	zoo	except	the
pinguini.								
penguins								

'# I saw all the mammals at the zoo except the penguins.'

c.

*Ho	visto	tutti	i	mammiferi	allo	zoo	tranne	ho
have.1SG	seen	all	the	mammals	at.the	zoo	except	have.1SG
visto i	pinguini.							
seen the	penguins							

Sentence (7a) involves genuine clausal coordination. The first conjunct expresses universal quantification over *mammals*, while the second conjunct introduces a negative proposition concerning *penguins*. Since the two propositions refer to distinct biological domains, the coordination is logically coherent and fully acceptable. By contrast, sentence (7b) is semantically anomalous. Because penguins are *not* mammals, they cannot be subtracted from the set denoted by the nominal restriction. This contrast suggests that exceptive constructions operate through domain subtraction on the restriction of the quantifier, rather than through the coordination of independent propositions.[2] If (7b) were derived from an underlying structure such as *tranne non ho visto i pinguini* ('except I did not see the penguins'; see (7c)), as predicted under a clausal ellipsis analysis, the sentence would be expected to be as

[2] Proponents of the clausal ellipsis hypothesis argue that the licensing of Negative Polarity Items (NPIs) inside exceptive phrases (e.g., *John danced with everyone except with any girls from his class*) constitutes evidence for an elided sentential negation. Under this view, the NPI is locally licensed by a *phantom negation* within the unpronounced clause. However, as Stockwell & Wong (2020) point out, this stripping derivation is syntactically flawed: moving an NPI out of the c-command domain of its licensor systematically results in ungrammaticality in English (e.g., **Which pictures of any of his friends does Sam not like?*). Therefore, the NPI cannot be licensed by a deleted sentential *not*. Instead, as demonstrated by Gajewski (2008), true exceptive constructions inherently create a downward-entailing (or anti-additive) environment through the mereological operation of domain subtraction. The subtractive polarity is an inherent lexical property of the relational exceptive head, licensing NPIs locally without the computationally costly postulation of invisible clausal negation.

acceptable as (7a). However, this prediction is not borne out, since the sentence (7c) is ungrammatical.[3]

2.2 Focus-Fronting and P-Stranding Constraints

The derivation proposed under a clausal ellipsis analysis relies heavily on movement. In order to derive a free exceptive via stripping, the remnant must undergo A′-movement—typically focus fronting—to the left periphery (Spec-CP) of the exceptive clause before TP-deletion applies. While such derivations are possible in English, they are problematic in Romance languages (Rizzi 1982, Kayne 1984), which generally prohibit preposition stranding and instead require pied-piping of the preposition.[4] Consider the example in (8).

(8) Italian

Ho	parlato	con	tutti	tranne	che	con	Gianni.
have.1SG	spoken	with	everyone	except	COMP	with	Gianni

'I spoke with everyone except Gianni.'

Under a clausal analysis, *tranne* would coordinate two CPs. On such an approach, the PP *con Gianni* in (8) would have to be extracted from the elided TP (e.g. *non ho parlato con Gianni*) prior to ellipsis. However, deriving this configuration requires movement of the PP to the left periphery of the exceptive clause in a language that does not permit preposition stranding. This in turn entails extensive pied-piping of the preposition, which interacts poorly with

[3] To account for the negative entailment associated with exceptive constructions (e.g., the inference that Eva did not come in *Every girl came except Eva*), Vostrikova (2021) proposes that the ellipsis site within the reduced except-clause contains an implicit negation (roughly: *except Eva did not come*). The main empirical motivation for this proposal is, as already shown in fn.2, the licensing of Negative Polarity Items (NPIs) within the exceptive clause. However, deriving this interpretation through ellipsis raises theoretical questions. Standard ellipsis phenomena are generally assumed to require a close degree of semantic and syntactic identity between the antecedent and the elided material. Introducing a polarity element in the elided clause that is absent from the antecedent potentially weakens this identity requirement, since the grammar must supply additional material not overtly present in the surface structure in order to derive the intended interpretation. Within the analysis proposed here, the negative entailment associated with exceptive constructions does not require the presence of an implicit clausal negation. Instead, it follows from the semantics of exclusion itself: the subtractive relation introduced by the exceptive marker creates a downward-entailing environment that naturally licenses NPIs at the syntax–semantics interface. On this view, the relevant polarity effect is a lexical-semantic property of the relational exceptive head rather than the result of an unpronounced clausal negation inside the ellipsis site.

[4] In languages that do not permit preposition stranding, a clausal ellipsis analysis would require the entire PP to undergo pied-piping to the left periphery of the exceptive clause prior to TP-deletion. However, analyses of Romance left-peripheral syntax have shown that such configurations interact poorly with independently established constraints on focus and topic positions. As a result, the structures predicted by this derivation are often prosodically and syntactically disfavored (cf. Rizzi 1997, Belletti 2004).

independently established constraints on word order and movement in Italian. As a consequence, it is not straightforward to derive these structures through standard A′-movement under a clausal ellipsis analysis. The connectivity observed in these constructions instead resembles that of *phrasal adjuncts* modifying a nominal domain, rather than that of independent propositional units.

2.3 The Illusion of PP Remnants and the Role of the Italian linker *che*

One of Vostrikova's (2021) central arguments against a phrasal analysis is the existence of non-DP remnants. If an exceptive marker is a preposition or a relational noun, it should strictly select for a DP complement. How, then, can we explain sentences where the exceptive hosts a PP, as seen in English (9) and Italian (8) and (10)? Vostrikova concludes that because a PP cannot restrict a nominal domain, it must be the remnant of an elided clause.[5]

(9) I got no presents except from my mom.

(10) Italian

Ballerò	con	tutte	tranne	che	con	Maria.
dance.FUT.1SG	with	all	except	COMP	with	Maria

'I will dance with everyone except with Maria.'

This objection can be reconsidered once the morphosyntactic nature of categorial selection in Romance is taken into account. As we will discuss in greater detail in Sections 5 and 6, exceptive markers can be analyzed as *Axial Parts* (AxPs) within a *Double-Relator Model*. In this framework, they select a lower relational head (labeled *p lower*) that establishes the relation with the Ground. In Italian, when the Ground is realized as a DP, the default exponent of this lower relator is the preposition *di* ('of'), which assigns genitive case (11a); alternatively, with

[5] It is interesting to notice that Stockwell & Wong (2020) argue that sprouting constructions involving exceptives (e.g., *Everyone likes the movie except John, but I don't know why*) are ambiguous, and argue that the reading inquiring about the exception (*why John doesn't like it*) requires an elided clausal antecedent (*John didn't like the movie*). However, this conclusion unnecessarily conflates semantic recovery with strict syntactic isomorphism. Following the Question Under Discussion-based approach to ellipsis resolution (Griffiths 2019), the meaning of a fragment or sprout can be recovered from an implicit Question Under Discussion invoked by the explicit assertion. The utterance of an exceptive statement pragmatically raises the implicit question "Why is John an exception?", which provides the semantic antecedent for the *why*-sprout without requiring a fully-fledged, unpronounced clausal node in the syntax. Thus, we argue that sprouting ambiguity is a matter of discourse-pragmatic inference rather than evidence for clausal ellipsis.

highly grammaticalized markers (11b), the relator may remain phonologically null (cf. Kayne 2005, 2010).[6]

(11) Italian

a.	Ballerò	con	tutte	ad	eccezione	di	Maria.
	dance.FUT.1SG	with	all	to	exception	of	Maria
b.	Ballerò	con	tutte	tranne Ø	Maria.		
	dance.FUT.1SG	with	all	except	Maria		

Crucially, the preposition *di* rigidly selects a DP. It cannot embed another PP. Therefore, when the domain subtraction requires a PP to serve as the Ground, the syntax cannot utilize *di* or a null relator. Instead, the grammar resorts to the insertion of the functional linker/ complementizer *che*.

(12) Italian

a.	*Ballerò	con	tutte	ad	eccezione	di	con	Maria.
	dance.FUT.1SG	with	all	to	exception	of	with	Maria
b.	Ballerò	con	tutte	tranne	che	con	Maria.	
	dance.FUT.1SG	with	all	except	COMP	with	Maria	

In (12b), *che* should not be analyzed as a complementizer introducing a clausal projection. Rather, within Romance morphosyntax it may function as a generalized D-linker (akin to a determiner/demonstrative pronoun, cf. Kayne 2010, Manzini & Savoia 2003), capable of connecting relational heads with non-nominal complements. In the present analysis, *che* realizes an abstract relational head that surfaces when ordinary case-assigning prepositions are unable to satisfy the selectional requirements of the construction. This use of *che* is not restricted to exceptive constructions. A closely parallel configuration is found in comparative structures such as *più bello che intelligente* ('more beautiful than intelligent'), where *che* links two adjectival phrases without projecting a full clause. In both cases, *che* operates as a morphosyntactic linker (Franco et al. 2015, Manzini et al. 2019) rather than as a

[6] Even when the lower relator *di* is not overtly realized, exceptive markers still assign an oblique form to pronominal complements. This is illustrated by contrasts such as *Ha colpito tutti tranne me/te* ('He hit everyone except me/you'), where nominative forms are excluded (**tranne io/tu*). This pattern parallels the behavior of Italian prepositions, which likewise require oblique pronominal forms (*con me* 'with me', *per te* 'for you', *senza di lui* 'without him'). The distribution of pronominal case therefore suggests that a lower relational head is syntactically present even when phonologically null, licensing an oblique/genitive form on the Ground..

complementizer introducing CP structure. Under this view, the presence of a PP complement after an exceptive marker does not constitute evidence for clausal ellipsis.[7] Instead, it reflects the morphosyntactic strategy by which the grammar satisfies categorial selection when the Ground is not a DP, resulting in a purely phrasal relational structure. We will return to this issue in Section 5.

3. Relational Primitives, Mereology, and Zonal Inclusion

A proper understanding of the syntax of exceptive constructions requires a framework that represents spatial and abstract relations in terms of minimal relational predicates. The Double-Relator Model (DRM), developed in Franco (2024) and Franco & Schirato (2026), provides such an approach. Within this framework, complex prepositional expressions are analyzed not as lexicalized or opaque units, but as transparent syntactic configurations whose internal structure can be systematically decomposed.

3.1 The Architecture of the Double-Relator Model

The conceptual and syntactic foundation of the Double-Relator Model (DRM) is strictly rooted in the theoretical framework developed by Manzini & Savoia (2011, 2018), Manzini & Franco (2016), and Franco & Manzini (2017). In these works, it is extensively argued that adpositions and oblique cases are never semantically vacuous functional heads (e.g., K heads or dummy Case markers, see Bittner & Hale 1996, among many others) inserted purely for syntactic licensing. Instead, they are active, interpretable elementary predicates that compute basic mereological relations, specifically inclusion ($\subseteq$) and inverse inclusion ($\supseteq$). Building upon this premise, the DRM expands the logic of elementary predicates to complex spatial and abstract adpositional expressions, integrating it with a Figure–Ground model (see Svenonius 2006). Within this architecture, complex adpositions (e.g., Italian *di fronte a* 'in front of', *per mezzo di* 'by means of') involve an Axial Part (AxP) or Relational Noun (RelN) embedded

[7] Vostrikova (2021) further argues against a phrasal/subtractive analysis by claiming that prepositional remnants create a semantic type mismatch. For instance, in *I met a student from every city in Spain except from Barcelona*, she argues that subtracting the set of things *from Barcelona* from the nominal domain *cities in Spain* is mathematically impossible, allegedly forcing a clausal derivation. This objection, however, overlooks the internal structure of the quantified antecedent, which already contains a matching prepositional restriction (*from every city*). As we will show in greater details in the next section, within a relational framework, the subtraction operates over matching prepositional entities/events via C-selection, or over n-tuples via Polyadic Quantification (Moltmann 1995). The syntax directly subtracts the spatial origin (*from Barcelona*) from the domain of spatial origins (*from every city*), effectively circumventing any artificial type mismatch without resorting to clausal ellipsis.

between two relational heads. According to the Double-Relator Model (DRM), spatial adpositions and oblique cases can be understood as externalizations of elementary predicates encoding inclusion and part–whole relations. The conceptual background of this approach, as said, draws on the Figure–Ground model (Talmy 2000, Svenonius 2006, cf. Borer 2005). Within this framework, complex adpositional expressions (e.g. Italian *di fronte a* 'in front of', *per mezzo di* 'by means of') involve an Axial Part (AxP) or Relational Noun (RelN) embedded between two relational heads. The general structural template for complex relational phrases can be schematized as follows:

(13) [XP Figure [p_upper $_{(\subseteq)}$ [AxP AxPart/RelN [p_lower $_{(\subseteq)}$ [XP Ground]

In the configuration in (13), p_upper is a higher relator that connects the external Figure (a modified DP/Event) to the Axial Part. The p_lower is a lower relator that connects the Axial Part to the Ground DP (or event). Each p represents an abstract relational predicate — essentially a minimal prepositional element carrying a general meaning of inclusion, that can be formally notated as (⊆).[8]

For example, in the Italian phrase *il lago ai piedi del monte* ('the lake below the mountain', lit. 'the lake at the feet of the mountain'), the adposition *a* functions as *p_upper*, relating the Figure to the relevant spatial region. The noun *piedi* ('feet') realizes the *Axial Part / Relational Noun*, denoting the region that serves as the reference zone, while *di* functions as *p_lower*, linking this region to the Ground (*il monte*).

The resulting configuration reflects the compositional logic of the Double-Relator Model: the Figure is included in the region defined by the Axial Part, and that region is in turn included in the Ground. In other words, the structure encodes a nested relation of inclusion (*Figure ⊆ Region ⊆ Ground*), which explains why the DRM posits two relational heads.

This configuration illustrates the morphosyntactic transparency assumed in the DRM: each lexical element corresponds to a distinct structural position and contributes a specific relational meaning. Furthermore, Svenonius (2006) provides diagnostics distinguishing Axial Part**s** from ordinary nouns. In their relational use (e.g. *fianco* 'side' in *di fianco a* 'beside'), Axial Parts typically do not combine with determiners, resist pluralization, and show limited compatibility with nominal modifiers.

[8] The notation (⊆) is employed here not in the strict mathematical sense of subset-hood, but rather as a generalized predicate of "zonal inclusion" (Belvin & den Dikken 1997), capable of capturing locative, possessive, and partitive relations within a unified cognitive-spatial schema.

3.2 Mereology and Zonal Inclusion: (⊆) and (⊇)

The syntactic structure of adpositions can be directly related to mereological semantics**.** Formal semantic approaches have long employed extensional mereology (Link 1983) to model the interpretation of mass nouns and plural reference. However, relational elements such as adpositions require a framework that also captures spatial structure and boundary relations, as provided by *mereotopological* approaches (Varzi 2007, 2021). In this perspective, the functional lexicon is not assumed to be rigidly predetermined in a cartographic hierarchy; rather, it is drawn from the same conceptual inventory that underlies lexical categories.
In order to provide a unified account of locative, possessive, and partitive relations, we adopt the notion of *zonal inclusion*, originally proposed by Belvin and den Dikken (1997). Zonal inclusion captures the idea that an entity or eventuality may be located within a *region* associated with another entity without being strictly contained within it. As we have already pointed out, formally, the relation can be represented by the predicate ⊆, which expresses that one entity is included in the zone associated with another. Its converse relation, ⊇, expresses the inverse configuration, whereby an entity contains or encompasses another. These minimal relational predicates can be taken to underlie a wide range of constructions, including possessive, comitative, locative, and partitive relations.
To illustrate how these elementary predicates encode different directions of inclusion, consider the contrast between *adnominal possession* and *comitative relations* in Italian, as discussed in Franco & Manzini (2017).

(14) Italian

a. I bambini della mamma
the children of.the mother
'The children of the mother'

b. La mamma con i bambini
the mother with the children
'The mother with the children'

As argued by Manzini & Savoia (2011) and Manzini & Franco (2016), the genitive preposition *di* ('of') is not a semantically vacuous dummy case marker; it is the overt externalization of the elementary predicate (⊆). In (14a), *di* introduces a possession relation where the possessum (*i bambini*) is structurally linked to the possessor (*la mamma*). The children are zonally included within the mother's domain. Conversely, Franco & Manzini (2017) demonstrate that the preposition *con* ('with') in (14b) realizes the inverse inclusion predicate (⊇). In this configuration, *con* embeds the possessum (the children) rather than the possessor, expressing that the mother mereologically includes (i.e. is accompanied by) the children. Crucially, notice that both predicates ((⊆) and (⊇)) are lexicalized by simple, monosyllabic relators (*di* and *con*).

3.3 The Syntax of Partitives: Simple Subset Extraction

If the Double-Relator Model relies on mereological inclusion, partitive constructions provide the baseline for subset extraction. In a standard partitive construction, the syntax isolates a subset from a maximal set.

(15) Italian

Due dei	ragazzi
two of.the	boys

'Two of the boys.'

Recent cartographic analyses of partitive constructions (e.g. Cardinaletti & Giusti 2016; Falco & Zamparelli 2019, 2024) assume a richly articulated internal structure for the noun phrase. In order to derive expressions such as *due dei ragazzi* ('two of the boys'), these approaches posit multiple functional projections, including layers such as NumP (Number Phrase) and PlP (Plural Phrase). Within this framework, the preposition *di* ('of') is typically treated as a functional element whose primary role is to satisfy case-related requirements rather than to contribute an independent semantic relation.
One consequence of this view is that the morphophonological identity between the partitive article (e.g. *dei* in *ho visto dei ragazzi* 'I saw some boys') and the articulated genitive/partitive preposition (*dei*) must be treated as accidental or historically contingent.[9]

[9] Under our view, the homophony between the partitive article and the genitive preposition is anything but accidental. The grammar systematically deploys the exact same lexical item — the inclusion relator (⊆) — to select plural or mass cumulative entities (Manzini & Savoia 2011). The syntax is therefore stripped of empty functional heads and dummy Case markers, relying entirely on lexical material that projects genuine partitive-inclusive semantics. The preposition *di* is an active, interpretable relational head that inherently computes a part-whole mereology. In the specific case of the partitive article, this inclusion relator (⊆) is deployed to select and operate over plural or mass entities. Crucially, the compatibility of the (⊆) relator with mass nouns and

The DRM, developed within a minimalist perspective, adopts a different analysis. Rather than positing additional functional projections, the DRM treats the preposition *di* as the overt realization of an elementary relational predicate expressing mereological inclusion (⊆). In a partitive construction such as *due dei ragazzi*, the relation is straightforward: a subset is identified within a maximal set. The numeral *due* denotes the extracted subset, which is interpreted as being included (⊆) within the domain denoted by the DP *i ragazzi* (the whole). Under this approach, the syntactic structure reduces to a simple relational configuration:

(16) [XP *part* [pP(⊆) [DP *whole*]]]

While partitive constructions involve a simple inclusion relation between a subset and a maximal set, exceptive constructions require a more articulated configuration, since they encode the (somewhat) complementary operation of domain subtraction, as we will see in the next section.

4. The Mereology of Exclusion: Exceptives (and Abessives)

It is frequently assumed in descriptive literature that exception is the mirror image of partitivity. If a partitive merely extracts a part from a whole ($P \subset W$) (cf. Moltmann 1997), an exceptive subtracts a part from a maximal whole ($W \setminus P$) (von Fintel 1993, Moltmann 1995). However, when viewed through the lens of mereotopology and syntax, this symmetry breaks down.

4.1 The Structural Asymmetry: Why Exception (and Absence) Needs More Structure

As we have seen above, in a partitive phrase (*due dei ragazzi*), the grammar only needs a simple relator (⊆) to link a subset directly to the maximal set. The part is treated as a structurally integrated entity within the whole (Moltmann 1997). Similarly, in a comitative relation (*la mamma con i bambini*), the inverse inclusion (⊇) directly links the entities.

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plurals is not arbitrary; it stems directly from their shared mereological architecture. As established in formal semantics (Quine 1960; Link 1983), both mass terms (e.g., *bread* or *gold*) and plural terms (e.g., *boys* or *horses*) are defined by the property of *cumulative reference*: the mereological sum of two instances of gold is still gold, and the sum of two groups of horses is still horses. Because these entities denote unbounded, cumulative aggregates rather than singular bounded individuals, the inclusion relator (⊆) is perfectly equipped to partition them, extracting an indefinite subset or sub-quantity from the maximal mass or plural kind. By analyzing *di* as a (⊆) predicate, we achieve strict theoretical parsimony: the phonological identity between genitive and partitive forms is directly isomorphic to their underlying syntactic and mereological identity.

Exceptives, conversely, cannot simply link a subset to a set via a basic preposition, because the entity being introduced is explicitly *denied* membership in the active quantificational domain. To execute this subtraction, the grammar must actively delineate a boundary: it must create a specific "zone of exclusion" (to mirror Belvin & den Dikken's zonal inclusion).
In mereotopological terms (see Varzi 2007, 2021), exception creates a "hole" or boundary within the universal set. Syntactically, an elementary inclusion predicate (⊆) is incapable of defining a *boundary* on its own. To subtract an entity, the grammar must project an Axial Part (AxP) to serve as the spatial/abstract boundary of exclusion.
This asymmetry is not unique to exceptives; it is perfectly mirrored in the morphosyntactic relationship between the comitative and the abessive/caritive (the case or adposition expressing absence or lack).[10]

(17) Italian

a. La mamma con i bambini/me (Comitative: Inverse Inclusion ⊇)
‘the mother with the children/me’

b. La mamma senza i bambini/di me (Abessive: ‘zone of absence’)
‘the mother without the children/me’

While the comitative uses a simple, monosyllabic relator (*con*), its negative/exclusive counterpart requires the polysyllabic item *senza* ('without') (Rizzi 1988). Crucially, *senza* behaves as an Axial Part. *Senza* often allows/ licenses a lower simple relator (*di*) when taking certain grounds, such as pronouns (*senza di te* 'without of you', see 17b). The ‘complex’ abessive *in assenza di* ('in absence of') makes this underlying bipartite AxP structure fully transparent. Consider the examples in (18).

(18) Italian

a. Senza aiuto, i costi saranno insostenibili
‘Without support, the costs will be unsustainable.’

b. In assenza di aiuto, i costi saranno insostenibili
‘Without support, the costs will be unsustainable.’

[10] The structural symmetry between comitatives and abessives is robust across languages. While the comitative typically employs a simple inclusion relator (⊇) the abessive frequently recruits a complex spatial or relational noun (e.g., 'absence', 'lack', 'outside') functioning as an Axial Part to create the negative boundary, confirming that exclusion consistently requires more syntactic structure than inclusion (cf. Stolz et al. 2006, 2007).

The fundamental structural asymmetry between the grammar of inclusion and the grammar of exclusion, within the DRM, can be summarized as follows.
The Partitive relation involves the operation of subset extraction ($P \subset W$). Cognitively, it maps onto a space of integrated parthood and is syntactically headed by a simple relator (⊆), as seen in the Italian *una parte/due dei ragazzi* ('a part/two of the boys'). Similarly, the Comitative relation expresses inverse inclusion (⊇). Its cognitive spatial map is one of accompaniment, and it is likewise headed by a simple, monosyllabic relator, as in *la mamma con i bambini* ('the mother with the children'). Simple relators are perfectly equipped to link entities that are positively *integrated* with one another.
In contrast, the exceptive relation performs domain subtraction ($W \setminus P$). From a cognitive and mereotopological perspective, subtracting an entity from a universal domain amounts to creating a "void" or a "hole" within that set. Here lies, cognitively, the core of the structural asymmetry. As Varzi (2007) demonstrates, pure mereology (the formal theory of parthood) only possesses the conceptual resources to deal with existing, integrated parts. It lacks the tools to account for voids, boundaries, and connectedness. To execute a mereological subtraction (what Varzi calls the *Relative Complementation Principle*), natural language must shift from pure mereology to topology.
How does the grammar isolate and manipulate a "hole" in a quantificational domain? Philosophically and topologically, a hole is essentially "nothingness." Identifying a void as a specific, computable entity requires drawing its boundaries. As Varzi (2007) points out, drawing the boundary of a hole is the only way to confer "ontological dignity" to the void itself, turning it into a discrete object of discourse. Syntactically, the grammar mirrors this topological necessity. An inclusion predicate (⊆) (like a simple preposition or a case marker) is structurally incapable of defining a topological boundary on its own; it can only link arguments/events. Therefore, to subtract an entity and grant "ontological dignity" to its exclusion, the syntax is forced to project specific spatial (or, in any event *lexical*) material to reify the boundary. This boundary-setting element is the Axial Part (AxP) (e.g., *tranne*, *eccetto*, *salvo*) or a Relational Noun (*eccezione*). The Axial Part acts exactly as what Varzi (2007) defines as the "internal skin" or interface between the *matter* (the universal domain) and the *void* (the exception).
This explains the fundamental morphosyntactic divide. Partitivity and comitativity only require simple inclusion predicates (P heads) because they link existing matter. Conversely, exceptives — operating via "zonal exclusion" — must syntactically build a topological

boundary around the subtracted entity. Consequently, they require the complex bipartite syntax of the Double-Relator Model, where an Axial Part/Relational Noun is sandwiched between relators (e.g., *tutti ad eccezione dei ragazzi* 'everyone to the exception of the boys'). This principle extends beyond exceptives: perfectly mirroring this architecture, the abessive relation (zonal absence) also requires delineating an empty region, dictating the use of an Axial Part as its syntactic head, as demonstrated by the complex preposition *in assenza di aiuto* ('in the absence of help').

Ultimately, the DRM proves that the exceptive marker is not a unique propositional operator or a clausal coordinator, but rather a spatial/relational noun (AxP) explicitly co-opted by the syntax to trace an abstract topological boundary.

4.2 Analytic Exceptives: The Transparent Proof

The most transparent evidence for this expanded "zonal exclusion" structure comes from analytic constructions in Romance, such as the Italian *ad eccezione di* ('to the exception of'), *all'infuori di* ('to the outside of'). Consider the examples in (19):

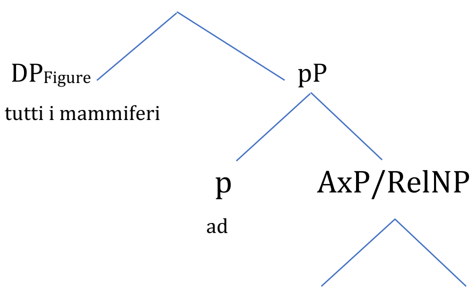
(19) Italian

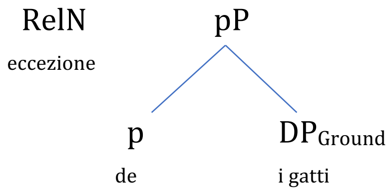
a. Tutti i mammiferi ad eccezione dei gatti.
   all the mammals to exception of.the cats
   'All mammals, with the exception of cats.'

b. Ho assaggiato tutti i funghi edibili, all'infuori dei dormienti.
   'I tasted all the edible mushrooms except (lit: at the outside of') the March mushroom' (*Hygrophorus marzuolus*).

In (19), the morphosyntactic mapping onto the DRM explicitly reveals the extra structural layers. Consider the structure in (20) for the example in (19a):

(20)





The syntactic tree for this exceptive phrase does not contain a CP, a TP, or a vP. It is a strictly nominal extended projection that builds a topological boundary. The phrase asserts that the Figure is situated relative to the exclusion zone defined by the Ground.

4.3 Grammaticalized AxP Markers: *Tranne*, *Eccetto*, *Senza*

If the analytic *ad eccezione di* fits the DRM and proves the necessity of the AxP layer, how do we analyze grammaticalized, monomorphemic exceptive markers like Italian *tranne* or *eccetto*?

Following Franco & Schirato (2026), Relational Nouns (such as *fronte*, *mezzo*, *capo*) frequently grammaticalize into Axial Parts. Over time, these markers become inherently specified as AxPs in the lexicon. Because they have undergone intense grammaticalization (see Heine and Kuteva 2002, Svenonius 2006), they frequently license null (silent) realizations of p_upper and p_lower. The postulation of silent relators is a well-documented phenomenon in the diachrony of adpositions; for instance, modern Italian *sotto il tavolo* ('under the table') features a silent p_lower ⊆, whereas it is also possible to transparently maintains the overt relator *sotto al/del tavolo*.[11] We can represent a grammaticized exceptive like *tranne* as in (21b).[12]

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[11] Regarding this overt/null alternation of the lower relator, some scholars have attempted to provide principled semantic explanations. For instance, Tortora (2005) and Folli (2008) propose that the presence of the overt preposition *a* (as in *dentro alla stanza* vs. *dentro la stanza*) encodes an aspectual feature of spatial *boundedness*, effectively parameterizing the structural difference. However, we maintain that this alternation often transcends strict semantic parameterization. In contemporary Italian, the choice between an overt or silent lower relator is arguably better understood as a matter of inter-speaker variability and register fluidity, rather than the projection of a dedicated aspectual node. Crucially, within the Double-Relator Model, whether the lower relator is phonologically realized or remains silent, the underlying mereological configuration of inclusion (⊆) remains fundamentally active and unchanged.

[12] From a theoretical perspective, the grammaticalization of monomorphemic exceptive markers (such as Italian tranne or eccetto) can be elegantly captured through the mechanism of phrasal spell-out, build within the Nanosyntactic framework (Starke 2009; Caha 2009). While standard approaches lead to postulate phonologically silent functional heads (∅) for the unpronounced upper and lower relators (cf. Kayne 2005), phrasal spell-out allows a single, grammaticalized lexical item to spell out a complex syntactic spine. Under this view, the diachronic process of grammaticalization — whereby complex, multi-word locutions like *trai ne* ('extract from it') or *exceptum* crystallize into dedicated exceptive markers — can be formalized as a lexical item expanding its spell-out domain. As the AxP grammaticalizes, it absorbs the p upper and p lower relational nodes into a single portmanteau spell-out, effectively internalizing the bipartite relational architecture without deleting the syntactic structure itself.

(21) Italian

a. Tutti i ragazzi tranne Gianni.

all the boys except Gianni

'All the boys, except Gianni.'

b. [DP$_{\text{Figure}}$ Tutti i ragazzi [pP Ø [AxP tranne [pP Ø [DP$_{\text{Ground}}$ Gianni]

The diachronic evolution of these markers provides striking confirmation of their status as relational, domain-partitioning heads rather than clausal coordinators. The Italian marker *tranne* derives from the imperative verbal complex *trai ne* ("extract from it"). This etymology is literally a morphological instruction for mereological subtraction/zonal exclusion. Similarly, *fuorché* derives from *fuori* ("outside") + *che*. *Eccetto* derives from the Latin past participle *exceptum* ("taken out") (see Herczeg 1985 and references cited there). These elements crystallized into prepositional/axial heads defining spatial and abstract boundaries, retaining their nominal selectional properties rather than evolving into CP-selecting complementizers.[13]

The structural assumptions of the Clausal Ellipsis approach and the Double-Relator Model can be starkly contrasted across several features. Regarding the basic category and syntactic structure, the Clausal Ellipsis model treats the marker as a coordinating conjunction projecting a full CP with TP-deletion, whereas the DRM categorizes it as an Axial Part (or Relational Noun) embedded within a phrasal PP. Semantically, the ellipsis account relies on propositional conjunction, while the DRM employs the mereological mechanism of zonal exclusion. Furthermore, to resolve polarity mismatches, the ellipsis approach must generate a 'phantom' negation at LF. In the DRM, the subtractive polarity is simply an inherent lexical property of the AxP. Finally, while the clausal ellipsis derivation fails in non-P-stranding languages, the DRM offers a universally applicable architecture.

[13] It is interesting to note a significant lexical asymmetry between English and Romance regarding the marker *but*. In English, *but* exhibits a syncretism: it functions both as a true adversative clausal coordinator (a Boolean operator, translating to Italian *ma*) and as an exceptive marker (an Axial Part, translating to Italian *tranne* or *eccetto*). This lexical ambiguity may have historically biased formal semantic analyses toward treating all exceptives as underlying clausal coordinators. Italian morphosyntax, however, strictly segregates the two functions (*ma (non)* vs. *tranne*), making the nominal/relational nature of the latter completely transparent. Furthermore, even within English, *but* and *except* are not syntactically identical; for instance, *except* easily hosts prepositional remnants (*except from John*), whereas exceptive *but* strongly resists them (*?but from John*). This suggests that *but* retains residual coordination-like constraints that true AxPs like *except* lack.

5. Categorial Selection, Linkers, and the Realization of the Lower Relator

One of the central arguments of Vostrikova (2021) and others against a phrasal analysis of exceptives, as we have said, is the existence of non-DP remnants. If an exceptive marker is a relational head, it should strictly select for a nominal complement (a DP). How, then, can we explain sentences where the exceptive hosts a Prepositional Phrase (e.g., *except with Mary*, or Italian *tranne che con Maria*)? Proponents of the clausal approach argue that since a PP cannot directly restrict a nominal domain, it must be the surviving remnant of an elided clause.
Within the Double-Relator Model (DRM), however, this distribution is entirely predictable once we distinguish between the relational heads (*p_upper*, *p_lower*) and the strict selectional requirements of the Axial Part. An Axial Part, being of nominal origin, c-selects for a D-layer. In standard cases, the Ground is a DP, and the lower relator is either silent or realized as the genitive *di* (e.g., … [AxP *eccezione* [p_lower *di* [DP *Maria*]]]).
As established in Section 2, the realization of p_lower is strictly dependent on the categorial nature of the Ground. Following Svenonius (2002, 2007), C-selection (categorial selection) operates strictly as the determination of syntactic conditions on a dependent, holding exclusively between a head and its internal argument (complement). Svenonius demonstrates that, cross-linguistically, adpositions and relational heads idiosyncratically determine the case and category of their complements.
With highly grammaticalized AxPs like *tranne* ('except'), the *p lower* is systematically phonologically null (Ø). When the subtracted Ground is a simple DP, the derivation proceeds seamlessly: [p_upper Ø [AxP *tranne* [p_lower Ø [DP *Gianni*]]]].
However, when the excluded entity is intrinsically a prepositional relation, the entire PP (e.g., *con Maria* 'with Maria') acts as the Ground, as in (22a). This creates a categorial mismatch: the null *p lower* rigidly c-selects for a D-layer, but its complement is a PP. To prevent a C-selection crash, the grammar resorts to the insertion of the functional element *che.*

(22) Italian

a.	Ballerò	con	tutte	tranne	che	con	Maria.	(= 12b)
	dance.FUT.1SG	with	all	except	COMP	with	Maria	
	'I will dance with everyone except with Maria.'							

b. [p_upper Ø [AxP tranne [p_lower Ø [Linker-D che [PP$_{\text{Ground}}$ con [DP Maria]]]]]]

Drawing on extensive theoretical work on Indo-European linkers (Manzini & Savoia 2003; Manzini & Savoia 2018), *che* is not (rigidly) a clausal complementizer introducing a CP. Rather, here it functions here as a generalized linker of category D.[14] In (22), the D-linker *che* acts as the structural "glue" between the null *p lower* and the prepositional Ground. It "dresses" the PP as a nominal, satisfying the C-selectional requirements of the inclusion predicate while elegantly preserving the purely phrasal, non-clausal architecture of the exceptive

Empirical evidence for this purely nominal selection comes from nominalized infinitives. In Italian, infinitives frequently behave as fully-fledged DPs denoting events. When an infinitive serves as the Ground of the exception, the D-linker *che* is morphosyntactically unnecessary and is overwhelmingly omitted by native speakers.

(23) Italian

a. Mi piace tutto, tranne (il) fumare.
'I like everything except (the) smoking.'

b. [p_upper Ø [AxP tranne [p_lower Ø [DP fumare]]]]

The grammaticality and high frequency of *tranne fumare* in (23) proves that when the Ground inherently possesses D-features (as the infinitival DP does), it embeds directly under the Axial Part. No phantom CP and no clausal ellipsis are required.[15]

6. Complex Remnants and Polyadic Quantification: Dismantling the Ellipsis Proof

The main challenge against any phrasal analysis of exceptives — and conversely, the primary empirical evidence adduced in favor of clausal ellipsis — is possibly the phenomenon of "multiple remnants" (or multiple exceptions). As observed by Moltmann (1995), an exceptive marker can host multiple constituents of different syntactic types that do not form a natural sub-clausal constituent.

[14] This configuration bears a striking theoretical resemblance to the cross-linguistic phenomenon of *Suffixaufnahme* (case-stacking), as analyzed by Manzini et al. (2019). In *Suffixaufnahme* constructions, specialized linking morphology is required to license the stacking of oblique relations.

[15] The optional variant *tranne che *(il) fumare* simply arises when the infinitive projects a larger, fully clausal structure (CP rather than DP), thereby triggering the re-insertion of the D-linker *che* to bridge the categorial mismatch. Ultimately, the presence of *che* is a reflex of local morphosyntactic checking, not evidence for clausal ellipsis.

(24) Every boy danced with every girl except John with Mary.

For proponents of the clausal ellipsis framework, such as Vostrikova (2021) and Potsdam & Polinsky (2019), sentences like (24) are clear empirical evidence against a phrasal account: because the string *John with Mary* does not form a standard nominal constituent, they assume it must necessarily be the residue of a complex clausal derivation involving multiple focus-fronting (A'-movement to the left periphery) followed by TP-deletion. Thus, the underlying source is proposed to be: *...except John did not dance with Mary*.
However, this clausal assumption relies on massive structural overgeneration and ignores the semantic reality of Polyadic Quantification. As Moltmann (1995) formally established, sentences containing multiple quantifiers (like *every boy* and *every girl*) do not merely denote stacked, independent monadic quantifications. Instead, they can and often do denote a single polyadic quantifier—a set of relations, mathematically modeled as *n-tuples*. In (24), the quantificational domain is the Cartesian product of the set of boys and the set of girls (BOYS×GIRLS).
Therefore, the exception being subtracted is not a fully articulated proposition. The exception is simply an n-tuple (the pair ⟨John,Mary⟩) that is mereologically subtracted from the dyadic quantifier ⟨EVERY BOY,EVERY GIRL⟩.[16] Within the Double-Relator Model, the Axial Part *tranne* simply takes this n-tuple as its internal Ground.

(25) Italian

a.	Ogni	ragazzo	ha	ballato	con	ogni	ragazza,	tranne
	every	boy	has	danced	with	every	girl	except
	Gianni	con	Maria					
	Gianni	with	Maria.					

'Every boy danced with every girl except Gianni with Maria.'

b. [pP Ø [AxP tranne [pP Ø [Ground n-tuple <Gianni, con Maria>]

The extraction of an n-tuple from a polyadic quantifier requires no bi-clausal derivation, thereby avoiding the computationally costly postulation of phantom variables and unrecoverable deleted material.

[16] As Moltmann (1995) notes, the formation of polyadic quantifiers allows natural language to evaluate pairs (or n-tuples) of entities against relations simultaneously, rather than iterating monadic quantifications. The exceptive directly targets this Cartesian product, extracting the specific pair.

How does the syntax bundle a DP (*Gianni*) and a PP (*con Maria*) into a single syntactic Ground without resorting to an overt conjunction or an elided TP? Standard minimalism advocates for a leaner syntactic tree coupled with a much richer syntax-semantics interface. If we abandon the rigid assumption that syntactic trees must perfectly mirror semantic composition node-for-node, we can allow the syntax to simply generate the strings as flat, concatenated adjuncts to the AxP.[17] The richer Conceptual-Intentional interface directly constructs the n-tuple for evaluation against the polyadic quantifier. We argue that this is more explanatory and less stipulative than the clausal ellipsis alternative, which forces the syntax to project entirely invisible, fully-fledged clauses solely to provide a frame for non-constituents.[18]

7. CP Grounds and "Clauses of Reserve"

A comprehensive theory of exceptives must also account for instances where the exceptive marker genuinely appears to introduce a full clause. In Italian, this is frequently seen with the marker *salvo*, yielding what traditional grammar terms "*subordinate di riserva*" (clauses of reserve) (cf. Bianco 2010).

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[17] Within a minimalist framework, the formation of these complex complements does not necessarily require the projection of silent clausal nodes such as CP or TP. We assume that the syntax can build a complex plural entity through the recursive Pair-Merge (adjunction) of the relevant constituents, effectively yielding a complex nominal tuple. The formation of *n*-tuples is independently required by the grammar in order to interpret polyadic quantification. The assumption of a Pair-Merged complex Ground does not introduce parametric problems, whereas the clausal ellipsis alternative requires extensive (and otherwise unmotivated) multiple A′-movement (focus fronting) of non-constituent material to the left periphery of the elided clause. As we have said, in non-P-stranding languages such as Italian, extracting multiple remnants (for example a DP and a PP) from an elided TP systematically leads to ungrammaticality. For this reason, analyzing the multiple remnants as a complex phrasal Ground embedded under the exceptive Axial Part is not only sufficient for the purposes of mereological subtraction, but also preferable in terms of structural economy and parametric consistency.

[18] It is important to note that the strictly phrasal and relational architecture proposed by the Double-Relator Model (DRM) is fully compatible with recent developments in the formal semantics of exceptive constructions. Recent distributed analyses (e.g., Gajewski 2013; Hirsch 2016; Crnič 2018) decompose the meaning of exceptives into two distinct components: a local domain-subtraction operator and a global exhaustification operator (Exh). In these approaches, the exceptive marker itself is purely subtractive: it removes the set of excepted individuals from the nominal restriction. The negative entailment and the Uniqueness/Leastness effects arise instead from the Exh operator, which takes scope over the proposition. We argue that the DRM provides an appropriate syntactic structure for this distributed semantic interpretation. If the exceptive marker is analyzed as an Axial Part expressing zonal exclusion, the model derives local domain subtraction directly within the extended nominal projection (DP). The result of this relational operation is a properly restricted quantificational domain, which can then serve as the input to the propositional Exh operator at the LF interface. This architecture avoids the type mismatches that arise in clausal analyses of exceptives, where the exceptive introduces a full proposition rather than a nominal restriction. In this way, the DRM offers a transparent morphosyntactic basis for the subtractive component identified in recent formal semantic accounts.

(26) Italian

Il	concerto	salterà,	salvo	che	non	smetta	di
the	concert	jump.FUT.3SG	except	COMP	not	stop.SUBJ.3SG	COMP

piovere.
rain.INF
'The concert will be canceled, unless it stops raining.'

Proponents of clausal approaches, such as Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén (2012), might view the string *salvo che* as a complex subordinating conjunction coordinating two propositions (paralleling the behavior of English *unless*). However, under the DRM, this structure provides striking confirmation of the adpositional, non-coordinating nature of the exceptive marker.

The DRM analyzes the entire CP (*smetta di piovere*) as the internal argument —the Ground— of the AxP *salvo*.[19] This is not an *ad hoc* derivation. Complex adpositions/Axial Parts in Romance often take CP Grounds. Consider temporal adpositions like *dopo* ('after') or *prima* ('before'): they require the identical linker *che* when taking a clausal complement (e.g. *prima [che piova]* 'before [that it rains]' vs. *prima* [*della pioggia*] 'before the rain').

Crucially, true coordinating conjunctions in Italian (*e* 'and', *o* 'or', *ma* 'but') strictly forbid the insertion of the linker *che* to introduce a coordinate clause (**ma che piove*, **e che piove*). The fact that *salvo* and *tranne* obligatorily require the D-linker *che* to embed a CP (just as they require it to embed a PP, as discussed in Section 5) proves that they are relational/ adpositional heads selecting a complement, not coordinating conjunctions on par with *and* or *but*. In (26), the AxP *salvo* delineates an exclusion region over a conditional or eventive space rather than a nominal set. The D-linker *che* bridges the Axial Part to the clausal Ground, satisfying C-selection. The DRM's recursive capacity easily accommodates CP Grounds

[19] Our analysis aligns with the descriptive distinction drawn by Ferrari & Manzotti (1994) between standard "complements of exception" and "clauses of reserve" (*subordinate di riserva*). While a standard exceptive subtracts a specific entity from a nominal quantificational domain (e.g., subtracting *John* from *every boy*), a clause of reserve operates as an eventive quantifier. In a context like (26), the realization of the main event (*the cancellation of the concert*) is presented pragmatically as almost certain within a domain of expected eventualities. The AxP *salvo* acts on this eventive or conditional space by subtracting a specific eventuality (*the rain stopping*) that would compromise or invalidate the realization of the expected event set. The Double-Relator Model captures this shift: "zonal exclusion" remains structurally identical, but the domain of application switches from individuals (entities) to possible situations or events.

without ever abandoning the core hypothesis that the exceptive marker itself is an Axial Part, rather than a clausal coordinator.[20]

8. Additive vs. Subtractive Markers: A Mereological Divide

The proposed DRM framework also provides a clean typological separation between true subtractive exceptives and additive markers. As noted by Mayr & Vostrikova (2023) for English *besides*, not all markers superficially resembling exceptives enforce domain subtraction. In Italian, the adpositional complex items *a parte* ('apart from') and *oltre a* ('in addition to/besides') function additively. They do not enforce the strict Condition of Inclusion (i.e. the "Penguin Test").

To observe this, consider the interaction of these markers with existential quantifiers. As established in Section 1, true subtractives (*tranne*, *eccetto*) strictly obey the Quantifier Constraint, rendering them incompatible with existentials (e.g., **Qualche ragazzo, tranne Gianni, ha superato l'esame* 'Some boy, except Gianni, passed the exam'). By contrast, additive markers freely modify existentials:

(27) Italian

Qualche	ragazzo	a parte	Gianni ha	superato	l'	esame.
some	boy	to part	Gianni has	passed	the	exam

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[20] Note that recently, Seguin (2024) has claimed that Italian *eccetto* exhibits a dual syntactic nature: while it acts as a phrasal exclusive marker with existential and numeral associates, it must be analyzed as a clausal coordinating conjunction hosting TP-ellipsis when associating with Universal Quantifiers. To support the clausal ellipsis derivation for *eccetto* + UQ, Seguin adopts diagnostics from Vostrikova (2021) and Stockwell & Wong (2020), specifically relying on the licensing of speaker-oriented adverbs and sprouting phenomena. However, under standard minimalist assumptions and the Double-Relator Model, these diagnostics do not necessitate a clausal architecture. Seguin (2024) notes that speaker-oriented adverbs (e.g., *purtroppo* 'unfortunately', *evidentemente* 'evidently') can appear inside the exceptive phrase (*Tutti sono venuti, eccetto purtroppo Gianni*), arguing that such adverbs require a CP projection to modify. However, this assumption overgenerates. In Romance, evaluating adverbs can legitimately adjoin to the extended functional projection of nominals and complex PPs. The adverb *purtroppo* in this context evaluates the *exclusion operation* itself (the mereological subtraction instantiated by the AxP), not a hidden proposition. The fact that the adverb scopes over the exception is entirely predicted by its adjunction to the high functional spine of the AxP phrase, requiring no unpronounced TP. Drawing on Stockwell & Wong (2020), Seguin (2024) argues that ambiguous *why*-sprouting in exceptives provides evidence for clausal ellipsis. In a sentence like *Ho invitato tutti eccetto Luca, ma non so perché*, the reading "...why I did not invite Luca" supposedly requires a syntactic clausal antecedent (*non ho invitato Luca*) inside the exceptive phrase to license the sluice. However, this relies on a strictly isomorphic view of ellipsis identity that is independently challenged. As Kroll (2019) and Ranero (2021) demonstrate, clausal ellipsis heavily tolerates polarity mismatches and can be licensed via semantic/discourse entailments rather than strict syntactic identity. Because the Double-Relator Model semantically computes the "zonal exclusion" of *Luca* from the event domain, the negative inference (*Luca was not invited*) is directly generated at the Conceptual-Intentional interface.

'Some boy, besides Gianni, passed the exam.'

(28) Italian

Non	ho	visto	nessuno	a	parte	Gianni.
Not	have.1SG	seen	nobody	to	part	Gianni

'I haven't seen anybody, apart from Gianni.'

(29) Italian

Oltre	a	Gianni	qualche	ragazzo	ha	superato	l'esame.
beyond	to	Gianni	some	boy	has	passed	the exam

'Besides Gianni, some boy passed the exam.'

Incidentally, the marker *oltre a* provides striking evidence for the abstraction of spatial regions into logical domains. Etymologically and synchronically, *oltre* has a clear locative core, meaning 'beyond' a physical boundary. However, in (29), the Axial Part *oltre* is interpreted entirely "beyond location," operating as an abstract additive domain marker rather than a pure spatial positioner.

The acceptability of *a parte* and *oltre a* with existential and negative polarity items (*nessuno*), and their ability to act as a Hanging Topic in the left periphery (Frascarelli & Hinterhölzl 2007), confirms their status as distinct structural entities.

From a mereological standpoint, this divergence is highly principled. True subtractives project an AxP whose *sandwiching* elementary predicates (⊆) actively construct a boundary (a hole) *within* the universal restriction set (W \ P). Because the exception must be drawn from within the whole, it is structurally bound to the quantified nominal host (accounting for the strict connectivity effects of Connected Exceptives).

Additive markers like *a parte* or *oltre a*, on the contrary, project an AxP that merely defines a spatial or logical region adjacent to, or outside of, an event domain, rather than subtracting from a nominal restriction.

9. Further Crosslinguistic Evidence

A universalistic perspective on grammar suggests that if the Double-Relator Model accurately captures the deep structure of exceptives, we should see this configuration overtly lexicalized across various languages. This is precisely what the empirical record reveals.

Persian, a language for which we have native informants, employs *joz* ('except') in at least two constructions: a simple item *joz* and a more complex sequence *be joz(-e)* (lit. "to/with the part of). Importantly, *joz*, according to our inofrmants, can appears with the Ezafe connector -e when followed by a noun phrase. For example, *(be) joz(-e)* man 'except me' in (30) shows Ezafe linking *joz* to its nominal ground. By Pantcheva's (2006) typology, many such markers behave like *Class 2* prepositions: they resist preceding determiners but take Ezafe (and even plural marking if a demonstrative is present). In contrast, Class 1 prepositions (e.g. be, dær, ta) cannot co-occur with Ezafe or a preceding demonstrative. Pantcheva proposes that Class 2 P's are hosted by an Axial Part head (AxPart) and are K-linked to a DP Ground, whereas Class 1 P's are hosted by simpler spatial heads. This in coherent with our proposal that exceptive *joz* is AxPart-like.[21]

In particular, the construction *be joz(-e)* provides an overt realization of the DRM, as noted in both diachronic and synchronic descriptions (Perry 2007). Historically and morphologically, it decomposes as follows: *be*, meaning 'to', 'at', or 'by' (p_upper), *joz,* meaning 'part' (borrowed from Arabic *juz'* 'part') (Axial Part), *-e*, which is the *Ezafe* linker.

Indeed, when *be joz* takes a complement, it optionally (especially in formal registers, as suggested by our native informants) utilizes the *Ezafe* as the linker to the nominal Ground. Consider the example in (30):

(30) Persian

Hame	madrak	gereft-and	be joz(-e)	man.
all	certificate	got-3PL	to part(-EZ)	me

'Everybody got their certificate except me.'

In Persian, the exceptive is explicitly constructed as a spatial/mereological complex PP. The presence of the preposition *be* mapping to *p_upper*, the nominal root *joz* mapping to the AxP, and the *Ezafe* mapping to the D-linker proves that exceptives are cross-linguistically built on

[21] Pantcheva states that *joz* is a Class 1 adposition, but as we have seen it may enter in the complex configuration *be joz(-e)*, typical of AxP items. Further notice that the exact theoretical status of the Persian Ezafe has been the subject of extensive debate in recent generative literature. Some scholars analyze the Ezafe as a genitive case-marker (Samiian 1983, 1994; Larson & Yamakido 2005; Larson & Samiian 2020). Others have proposed treating it as a phonological linker for non-projecting head nouns to indicate phrasing within the nominal constituent (Ghomeshi 1997), or as an agreement (Determiner-like) affix (Franco et al. 2015). Within the Double-Relator Model, this theoretical dichotomy is largely neutralized: whether conceptualized as a generalized structural linker or as the overt spell-out of an elementary genitive predicate, the Ezafe consistently acts as the lower relator, mediating the selectional relationship between the relational head (the Axial Part) and its nominal Ground.

relational noun structures, undermining the claim that they are universally derived from clausal coordination and ellipsis.

Furthermore, the *Homogeneity Condition* is at work also in Persian, as illustrated in (31), replicating the Italian examples in (7).

(31) Persian

a. Hame-ye pestândâr-hâ-râ didam, vali pingvin-hâ-(râ na-didam).
all-EZ mammal-PL-OBJ see.PST-1SG but penguin-PL-OBJ NEG-see.PST-1SG
'I saw all the mammals, but I did not see the penguins.'

b. # Hame-ye pestândâr-hâ-râ didam, be joz(-e) pingvin-hâ.
all-EZ mammal-PL-OBJ see.PST-1SG to except-EZ penguin-PL
'I saw all the mammals except the penguins.'
(anomalous: penguins ∉ mammals)

The phrasal and relational pattern extends well beyond the Indo-European family. However, when evaluating typological evidence, a methodological caveat is in order. Descriptive grammars often suffer from an observational bias, confusing true exceptive markers with simple boolean operators or adversative coordinators (e.g., words meaning 'but' or 'and not'). As we have shown, while boolean operators connect propositions, true exceptives encode a mereological operation of "zonal exclusion" and inherently behave as adpositions or relational nouns. Therefore, the apparent presence of "clausal" exceptives in some descriptive grammars possibly stems from a misclassification of standard coordination.

When we isolate true exceptive markers, the cross-linguistic evidence supports a nominal and relational architecture. Japanese provides some interesting evidence. If exceptive markers were truly Boolean coordinators adjoining full CPs (as the clausal ellipsis hypothesis dictates), they should embed finite clausal complements. The Japanese exceptive marker *igai* ('outside/except') provides a striking counterargument to this prediction. As extensively documented by Polinsky et al. (2024), *igai* functions categorically as a postposition that rigidly selects for a nominal complement (NP). When a Japanese exceptive construction requires a propositional Ground, the syntax cannot simply coordinate a finite CP. Instead, it

must deploy explicit nominalization strategies to satisfy the selectional requirements of the Axial postposition. This is achieved either by inserting a light noun/nominalizer (such as *koto* 'thing/fact'), yielding structures like *kuru-koto-igai* ('come-KOTO-except'), or by forcing the embedded predicate to adopt adnominal (noun-modifying) inflection. For instance, a copular predicate must take the adnominal suffix -*na* rather than the finite -*da* (e.g., *kanso-na-igai* 'simple-ADN-except' vs. **kanso-da-igai*). This obligatory morphosyntactic shift shows that the exceptive head is an inherently adpositional/axial element that c-selects for nominal features. It actively resists direct CP-coordination, forcing the syntax to nominalize the propositional Ground. This process is functionally identical to the insertion of the D-linker *che* in Italian (*tranne che...*), confirming the validity of the Double-Relator Model.
Further evidence emerges from the Austronesian family, where the abstract relational structure of the DRM is overt and morphologically transparent. In Tuvaluan, the marker expressing zonal exclusion is *naa* ('except') (Besnier 2000). Crucially, *naa* cannot directly merge with its nominal Ground; rather, it obligatorily requires the presence of the (case-marking) preposition *ko*. Under a clausal ellipsis approach, a marker like *ko* would be left unexplained or awkwardly treated as a remnant-focusing particle. Under the DRM, however, the derivation is straightforward: *naa* projects as the Axial Part denoting the exclusion boundary, while *ko* acts as the overt phonological realization of the lower relator, structurally linking the AxP to the Ground DP. A parallel relational mechanism operates in Maori, where the primary exceptive marker *haaunga* directly selects a nominal complement, disconfirming underlying sentential coordination (Bauer 1993).

10. Discussion and Conclusions

The theoretical debate surrounding exceptive constructions has long been polarized between those advocating for phrasal modification operations (Moltmann 1995; von Fintel 1993) and those arguing for fully-fledged clausal structures reduced by an ellipsis mechanisms (Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén 2012; Vostrikova 2021; Potsdam & Polinsky 2019). The present study has advanced a strictly phrasal/relational analysis of exceptives, couched in the Double-Relator Model, shifting the analytical burden away from invisible syntactic structure and towards the syntax-semantics interface.
By scrutinizing the empirical data, particularly from Italian morphosyntax, the clausal ellipsis hypothesis reveals theoretical and descriptive shortcomings. Analyzing exceptive markers as coordinating conjunctions carrying elided TPs fails to capture the intrinsic Condition of

Inclusion — that differentiates true mereological subtraction from logical propositional conjunction. The Double-Relator Model provides an elegant, non-stipulative alternative. Exceptive markers (*tranne*, *except*, *be joz, igai*) are categorized as Axial Parts (AxPs) or Relational Nouns. They project a spatial/abstract boundary that partitions a universal domain. Crucially, we demonstrated that the mereology of exception is not merely the symmetrical inverse of partitivity. While a partitive simply extracts a subset utilizing a primitive inclusion relator (⊆), an exceptive operation represents *zonal exclusion*, and establishing an exclusion zone inherently demands the bipartite syntactic architecture of an Axial Part rather than a simple preposition.

Furthermore, we have shown that the presence of a PP after an exceptive marker (e.g., *tranne che con Maria*) is not the surviving residue of a deleted clause. Rather, it is the result of strict morphosyntactic C-selection. Because the default lower relator *di* ('of') selects a DP, the grammar must resort to the generalized D-linker *che* to embed a PP Ground. The marker *che* is a structural linker. Similarly, the puzzle of multiple remnants (e.g., *except John with Mary*) dissolves when we recognize the semantic reality of Polyadic Quantification (Moltmann 1995). The syntax constructs a complex Ground representing an n-tuple, and the mereological subtraction operates over the relations at the Conceptual-Intentional interface.

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